

Dual delight: Samrat Rana, the reigning men's 10m air pistol World champion, had won the bronze medal in the individual competition and also helped the Indian men's team bag a silver. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

bronze, later said she had not realised that the sighting shots she believed she was taking at the end of the prone position were actually being counted towards her score.

Self-imposed changes

While some adjustments were mandated by the international federation, others were self-imposed. Double Olympic medallist Manu Bhaker won silver in the women's 25m pistol event, her first international medal since switching guns late last year. Anish Bhanwala, silver medallist at last year's World Championships in the 25m rapid fire event, had also made a change to his pistol grip but struggled at the Asian Championships.

Although he claimed bronze, Anish shot 574 in qualification, among the lowest scores of his career. While Manu appeared comfortable with her equipment change, Anish indicated he would likely revert to his previous grip. He had no regrets about testing it at the Asian Championships.

"It was important to try and use it here. It might not have worked out for me, but I won't wonder what I might have shot had I never made the change. It's better that I didn't shoot as well as I would have wanted at the Asian Championships rather than later in the year," he told *Sportstar*.

Bhanwala was not the only shooter looking to improve in the months ahead. Suruchi, who won three World Cup gold medals and another at the World Cup Final last year, finished outside the podium, while Rana, gold medallist at last year's World Championships, ended on the lowest step.

Yet Rana felt he gained from the experience. He was sixth about a third of the way into the final before regrouping to secure a medal. It was, he says, proof that he could deliver

under pressure. "It's hard when you are playing at home, and you aren't performing at the best level. It's not easy to just focus on your technique. But I executed every shot with proper technique, and that gives me the confidence that I can trust my technique and execute well," he said.

Most Indian shooters felt they benefitted from the competition, either by adapting quickly or by learning hard lessons. While the field may have been diminished, the maximum permitted three Indian shooters qualified for the final of every Olympic event. And although some scores were modest, there were notable performances as well. Niraj Kumar, who took silver in the men's 50m in the three positions

event, shot a career-high 593 in qualification.

In contrast to much of the field, former world champion Rudranksh Patil shot a solid 632.1 in the men's 10m air rifle, just 0.2 below what he managed with a stiffer jacket at last year's Asian Championships. Esha Singh, bronze medallist at last year's World Championships, produced a personal-best 589 in qualification in the women's 25m pistol.

Some of India's most striking performances came from shooters ineligible for senior medals or competing in junior categories. Subhash Sihag and Sainyam topped qualification in the men's and women's 10m air pistol events with scores of 585 and 584, respectively.

